

Final Research Paper Rubric

	Exemplary (A)	Proficient (B)	Developing (C)	Inadequate (D/F)	Pts
Argument & Claim Development — 40 pts					
Research Question & Thesis	A specific, researchable question organizes the paper. The thesis makes a non-obvious interpretive claim and previews the argument's main moves.	A thesis makes a defensible claim, but the position is somewhat predictable or the argument's structure is underpreviewed.	A thesis is present but announces a topic rather than advancing an independent claim. The research question is vague or overextended.	No discernible thesis or research question. The paper offers description or summary without a governing argument.	/ 20
Argument Structure & Development	Each section advances the thesis through a distinct sub-claim. The argument moves cumulatively — each section creates conditions for the next.	The argument is logically organized. Most sections connect to the thesis; some rely on summary rather than analysis.	Sections operate independently rather than cumulatively. The link between individual points and the central thesis is often implicit.	No argumentative structure. Points are arranged by topic; there is no cumulative movement toward a conclusion.	/ 20
Engagement with Secondary Literature — 35 pts					
Source Selection & Range	The bibliography reflects a deliberate range: sources on what others have argued on this topic; at least one that grounds the interpretive lens; sources that model the method of analysis; and sources on adjacent problems where relevant.	Most orientations are covered but uneven — one type may be thin, or sources are selected by topic proximity without clear attention to what each contributes.	Sources establish that others have worked on the topic but do not clearly ground a framework or model a method. The list reads as relevant titles rather than a considered intellectual set.	Sources are insufficient, too narrow, or uncited. The paper relies on general references or course readings alone.	/ 15
Quality of Engagement	The paper enters the conversation between sources rather than citing them sequentially. Sources are synthesized and placed in relation to each other and to the argument. The student's voice is distinct.	Sources are cited and summarized accurately. Occasional synthesis across sources; the student's own contribution is present but not always distinguished from source claims.	Sources are cited but mostly summarized. The paper restates what sources argue rather than deploying them in service of an original claim.	Sources are absent, misrepresented, or merely listed. No engagement with the secondary literature as interlocutors.	/ 15
Intervention & Positioning	The paper situates itself in the existing literature — identifies what prior accounts leave unresolved and articulates the student's own contribution.	The paper's relationship to the literature is mostly clear. There is an implicit sense of where the argument adds something.	The paper synthesizes the literature without identifying a gap or an intervention. The student's contribution is not distinguished from the sources.	No awareness of positioning. No sense of what the argument adds to or departs from in existing scholarship.	/ 5
Use of Evidence — 15 pts					
Evidentiary Reasoning	Evidence is selected to do specific argumentative work. The paper explains why evidence supports the claim it accompanies. Counter-evidence or competing interpretations are acknowledged where relevant.	Evidence generally supports the claims it accompanies. The connection is usually stated, though not always fully developed.	Evidence is present but loosely connected to claims. The paper asserts that sources support a position without explaining how.	Evidence is absent, irrelevant, or substituted by assertion. Claims rest on opinion rather than documented support.	/ 15
Writing & Citation — 10 pts					
Prose & Citation	Prose is clear, precise, and appropriately disciplinary. Chicago citations are complete and consistent; bibliography is properly formatted.	Prose is clear with occasional lapses. Citations present with minor errors; bibliography mostly correct.	Prose is sometimes unclear. Citation is inconsistent or incomplete.	Prose significantly impedes comprehension. Citations are absent or substantially incorrect.	/ 10
Total					/ 100